Khrushchev gave up hope of persuading Castro to allow any inspection on Cuban territory and with the bombers he was going to reach an agreement with the Americans to have ships inspected in neutral waters. But he wanted Mikoyan to get Castro's approval for the removal of the bombers. Khrushchev was counting on Mikoyan to deliver a miracle in Havana. "Received, read, considered. I consider the indicated decision on the IL-28s perfectly correct," responded the always loyal Mikoyan. He knew that he had no choice but to say yes. The decision that he diplomatically called "indicated" had been already made. Mikoyan could influence the decision-making process while in Moscow, but in Cuba, with Khrushchev saying that all Presidium members were already on board, he was little more than a high-ranking messenger with a salesman's task entrusted to him.

Mikoyan delivered the bad news to Castro at a private meeting on November 12. His sales pitch was that the removal of the bombers would help to secure a deal with the Americans. Castro was probably stunned, or perhaps triumphant, as he had predicted that making concessions to the Americans was a slippery slope. In any case, he refused to buy Mikoyan's argument. "Whatever position the Soviet Union settles on, regardless of whether you remove the bombers or not, the USA will insist on inspection and, on the pretext that Cuba will find this unacceptable, the US will maintain its blockade," he told the Soviet envoy. The experienced Mikoyan did not insist on an immediate response. In fact, he encouraged Castro to think things through and talk to his comrades.[7]

The Cuban reply to Mikoyan, and through him to Khrushchev, was delivered on the following day, November 13, at a meeting with the Cuban leadership in Mikoyan's temporary home in Havana. Castro interrupted the small talk that Mikoyan seemed to be enjoying at the start of the meeting to deliver his and his government's position on the bombers. "We basically did not agree with the removal of strategic missiles, just as we disagree with the removal of IL-28 bombers from Cuba," began Castro. He then explained the reason for Cuban disapproval: "These measures create a difficult situation for us. They undermine our sovereign right to determine for ourselves what type of weapons we can have, and what agreements we can make."